

Solitary hunters

The animal world is a place of constant danger, because predators are never far away. Some of them work in groups, but most hunt on their own, using specialized weapons to catch and kill their prey. They include animals that run their prey down or stealthily track their victims, and ones that do the exact opposite—keep still and wait for food to come within their reach. However they hunt, all predators have lightning-fast reactions—the key to making a successful kill.

Death in the trees

In the forests of Costa Rica, a venomous eyelash viper stabs a mouse with its fangs. This brightly colored snake lives in trees and bushes, from where it ambushes rodents, lizards, tree frogs, and birds. The viper's reactions are so quick that it can grab hummingbirds as they hover in front of flowers. Its powerful venom paralyzes its prey within seconds, making it easy for the snake to swallow whole.

Mouse hangs paralyzed by viper's venomous bite

Fatal fling

A young seal out at sea is easy prey for a great white shark. Bursting up to the surface from below, the shark hits its victim with such force that the seal is thrown out of the water before being snatched in the shark's large jaws. The shark is effectively camouflaged by its two-tone coloring, which makes it difficult to spot in the water from both above and below.



Patient killer

The praying mantis is a sit-and-wait killer that blends in well among the twigs and leaves. It rests with its front legs folded together, turning its head in all directions to watch for passing insects. If an insect lands within range,

the mantis slowly leans forward, then strikes with its front legs. Their tips snap together, trapping its prey between rows of spines like jagged knives. The mantis starts to feed immediately, while its live victim struggles to escape.

Front legs have inward-pointing spines that impale prey

